

History & Folklore In traditional North American herbal medicine, Canadian fleabane was boiled to make steam for sweat lodges, taken as a snuff to stimulate sneezing during the course of a cold, and burned to create a smoke that warded off insects—hence its common name.

Medicinal Actions & Uses An astringent herb, Canadian fleabane is taken for gastrointestinal problems such as diarrhea and dysentery. A decoction of Canadian fleabane is reportedly a very effective treatment for bleeding hemorrhoids. The herb is occasionally used as a diuretic for bladder problems, to clear toxins in rheumatic conditions, and to treat gonorrhea and other genitourinary diseases.

Related Species The Philadelphia fleabane (*E. philadelphicus*) was used by the Houma as a treatment for menstrual problems. *E. affinis*, a Mexican relative, is used to make a tooth powder and to treat toothache.

Copaifera spp. (Fabaceae) Copaiba

Description Evergreen trees growing to 59 ft (18 m). Have compound leaves and small yellow flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Copaiba is native to tropical South America, and also found in southern Africa. Oleoresin, a blend of volatile oil and resin often also referred to as copaiba, is obtained by drilling holes in the trunk.

Part Used Oleoresin.

Constituents The oleoresin contains a volatile oil (30–90%), which in turn contains alpha- and beta-caryophyllene, sesquiterpenes, resins, and terpenic acids.

History & Folklore Copaiba was used by native Brazilians long before the arrival of Europeans. In 1625, the Portuguese monk Manoel Tristaon observed that it was employed to heal wounds and remove scars.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Antiseptic, diuretic, and stimulant, copaiba is still used extensively in Brazil. Chiefly employed to counter mucus in the chest and genitourinary system, it irritates the mucous membranes and promotes the coughing up of mucus. A solution or tincture of copaiba may be taken for bronchitis, chronic cystitis, diarrhea, and hemorrhoids. Eczema and other skin diseases reportedly benefit from its application.

Related Species Several of the 40 *Copaifera* species yield a medicinal oleoresin.

⚠ **Caution** Copaiba is toxic in overdose. Use only under professional supervision.

Coptis chinensis (Ranunculaceae) Huang Lian (Chinese), Chinese Goldthread

Description Perennial herb growing to 20 in (50 cm). Has basal leaves and small whitish-green flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation This herb is native to the mountains of China, and is most commonly cultivated in Szechwan province. The root is dug up in autumn.

Part Used Root.

Constituents *Huang lian* contains isoquiniline alkaloids, including berberine, coptisine, and worenine. Berberine is antibacterial, amebicidal, and antidiarrheal.

Medicinal Actions & Uses A bitter-tasting herb, *huang lian* is given in the Chinese herbal tradition as a decoction to “clear heat” and “dry dampness,” relieving fever, red and sore eyes, and sore throats. The herb is particularly helpful for diarrhea and dysentery, and has been used to quell vomiting. Skin problems such as acne, boils, abscesses, and burns are also treated with *huang lian*. Like the root of goldthread (*C. trifolia*, see following entry), *huang lian* is taken as a gargle for mouth and tongue ulcers, and for swollen gums and toothache.

Research In a Chinese trial, 30 patients with tuberculosis were given *huang lian*, and all of them showed marked improvement in their symptoms.

⚠ **Cautions** Use only under professional supervision. Do not take during pregnancy.

Coptis trifolia (Ranunculaceae) Goldthread

Description Perennial growing to 6 in (15 cm). Has a slender golden root, 3-lobed leaves, and single small white flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to eastern North America from Labrador to Tennessee, this herb prefers damp sites. The rhizome is dug up in autumn.

Part Used Rhizome.

Constituents Goldthread contains isoquiniline alkaloids (including berberine and coptisine).

History & Folklore Though little used in herbal medicine today, goldthread was once highly valued. In a book recounting his travels in North America, published in 1779, Jonathan Carver states that the plant “was greatly esteemed both by the Indians and the colonists as a remedy for any soreness in the mouth.” The Montagnais used a decoction of the root for problems associated with the mouth, lips, and eyes. The Menominee used the plant as a gargle for children’s throat

problems and also to treat ulcers and tumors in the mouth.

Medicinal Actions & Uses A strongly bitter tonic, goldthread has been prescribed in the North American tradition principally for indigestion and stomach weakness, though it has also come under consideration as a treatment for peptic ulcers, and has been applied as a wash for vaginal yeast infection. Goldthread has been used as a mouthwash, gargle, or lotion for mouth ulcers, sore lips, and throats. The herb’s constituents (and to some degree its actions) are similar to those of goldenseal (*Hydrastis canadensis*, p. 105) and it has been used as a substitute for this herb.

Related Species *Huang lian* (*C. chinensis*, preceding entry) is a close relative that has similar actions.

⚠ **Cautions** Use only under professional supervision. Do not take during pregnancy.

Coriandrum sativum (Apiaceae) Coriander, Cilantro

Description Strongly aromatic annual growing to 20 in (50 cm). Has finely cut upper leaves (known as cilantro), small white or pink flowers, and rounded seeds (coriander) in beige seed coats.



Coriander was used as a digestive aid and a treatment for measles in 6th-century China.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to southern Europe and western Asia, the herb is cultivated throughout the world. The seeds are gathered ripe in late summer.

Parts Used Seeds, essential oil, leaves.

Constituents Coriander contains up to 1.5% volatile oil, consisting mainly of delta-linalool (at around 70%), alpha-pinene and terpinene. It also contains flavonoids, coumarins, phthalides, and phenolic acids.